

CHAPTER 10

Feeling toward, Befriending, and Exploring Protector Fears

In the last chapter we described the three exploratory steps we use to identify a target part, represented by the mnemonics *find*, *focus on*, and *flesh out*. Using these three steps, clients who are not familiar with their inner landscape learn to notice their parts, while those who are more accustomed to the world inside become adept at locating their parts. After these steps, we take three more—*feel toward*, *befriend*, and *fears*—that reveal the part’s motives and build its relationship with the client’s Self.

FEELING TOWARD

Every time we want to talk to a target part, and also any time we suspect another part has taken over from the client’s Self during the process of interviewing a target part, we ask the question: *How do you feel toward the [target] part?* (see [Box 10.1](#)). The client’s answer to this question reveals either a part (e.g., *I hate it! I’m afraid of it*, or *I pity it*) or the Self (e.g., *I’m curious*, *I feel bad for it*, or *I want to get to know it*). In this way, the *feel toward* question smokes out parts who are reacting strongly (either negatively or positively) to the target part. If the client’s answer reveals a reactive part, we help it relax and make room so more of the client’s Self can show up. Sometimes we have to ask several parts in a row to step back. If we find a part who will not step back, it becomes our new target of inquiry until it will step back.

BOX 10.1. How Do You Feel toward This (the Target) Part?

The client’s answer tells us:

- # If the target part is blended.
- # If a reactive part is blended.
- # How much of the client's Self is present.

The aim of the *feel toward* step is to introduce the client's parts to the client's Self. When the client's system is highly reactive and protectors will not cooperate we give up on this step temporarily and switch to direct access so the therapist's Self can befriend the target part and inquire about its fears. Once we switch to direct access, the important question is not how the client feels toward the target part but how the therapist feels toward it, which (if we are Self-led) should be somewhere from curious to compassionate.

The Room Technique

When the client's parts are less polarized and more differentiated from the Self, the client's parts are more cooperative and we are less likely to need to use direct access. Instead, we can just get to know the target part. Occasionally, however, it is too scared or shy to be noticed, or it alarms other parts. In this case, the room technique, mentioned earlier, is handy. We start by asking the client to put the scared or scary part in a room. Since the inner system experiences the room as a literal separation this helps in a couple of ways. First, the target part has containment and feels safer; and, second, other parts who dislike or fear the target part feel safer and are more likely to allow the client's Self to talk to it.

We have a couple of caveats regarding the room technique. To avoid the exile going right back to a room where something bad happened, we suggest starting with the instruction, *Put the part in a room or space that feels safe and comfortable*. If the target part balks at the idea of a room, it may like to hear that the goal is to help the client pay attention and listen so any contained space that feels safe, like a meadow, a glen in the woods, or a spaceship, would serve just as well as a room. The idea is to get physical separation. Illustrating that target parts feel liberated to show their feelings when they have this kind of containment, angry parts will often make a great show of storming around in the room, but they won't come out.

Remarkably, if the client agrees to put the part in a room and the part shows up in there (sometimes as a felt rather than a visual presence) the technique usually works to calm the reactivity of other parts, who become more willing to relax back. If the conversation is going well we can

follow up by asking if the Self can go into the room with the part to explore its state of mind and its priorities. Here is a vignette illustrating the room technique. Dakota, a 17-year-old girl, has found an old witch in her internal system who threatens other parts with spells and punishments.

THERAPIST: Put the witch in a room by herself while you stay outside the room.

DAKOTA: Okay, she's in there.

THERAPIST: How do you feel toward her now?

DAKOTA: Afraid because she's mean.

THERAPIST: Let me tell you an important law of the inner universe: When you're not afraid, mean or scary parts can't hurt you. Since the Dakota-who's-not-a-part won't be afraid of this mean one, you can ask the part who is afraid to relax for a few minutes and trust you.

DAKOTA: Who do you mean by "you"?

THERAPIST: I mean the Dakota-who's-not-a-part.

DAKOTA: (*after a pause*) Okay, the scared part is willing to try.

THERAPIST: How do you feel toward the witch now?

DAKOTA: Well, now I'm angry with her. I want her to go away.

THERAPIST: Okay. Ask the angry part to trust you for a few minutes, too. It could go in a waiting room, Would that work? Good. Now how do you feel toward the witch?

DAKOTA: She looks like a tired old lady. I feel sorry for her. Where did she come from?

THERAPIST: Ask her.

In order to see the witch more fully, Dakota had to help two parts unblend, the one who was afraid of her and the one who was angry with her. Sometimes we need to help as many as six or seven reactive parts before the Self is available to help the target part. We locate reactive parts who need help to unblend by asking the client, *How do you feel toward this part?* If the client's Self is available, the answer will reflect qualities of the Self, both in content and tone of voice. While we do not need reactive parts to unblend fully we do need them to unblend enough for the client to feel open and curious. Once the client reports feeling open toward the target part, we ask the client's Self to enter the room and learn about the part's fears.

Self-Like Managers

There is a certain kind of manager who is caretaking and solicitous. Managers like this can seem very much like the client's Self. Since they are easily confused with the client's Self, we refer to these managers as *Self-like*, though clients may come up with another name (e.g., *the look-alike part*

). It is important to remember that the agenda of a Self-like part is, no less than any other manager, to control other parts. Clients who are internally visual will see the Self-like part, which tells us it is a part and not the Self. This is because when the Self is embodied we see our arms, hands, nose, lap, and legs but we do not see a separate entity.

If the client does observe an image of herself interacting with her other parts, this is the Self-like part. We guide her to ask it to slide over a bit so that her Self can be present, too. Since Self-like parts prefer to be in the driver's seat they often deny being a part at first, and don't agree to unblend quickly. Lack of progress, especially when we believe the client has good access to Self and everything should be going well, is a sign that a Self-like part is blended. Likewise, a Self-like part may be in control when the client appears to be open but we still sense that she is being moved by a strong agenda.

BEFRIENDING

After making sure the client has sufficient Self-energy, we move on to befriending the target part. If it is cooperative and willing this step may pass virtually unnoticed. However, if the part is wary and concerned this step can take some time. As always, we explore the part's concerns. The part may need to spend more time with the client's Self to feel safe, it may need to know that the therapist isn't judging, or another part may be interfering. Novice IFS therapists can miss common signs of interference. These include the client—or the therapist—suddenly getting sleepy, changing the subject, losing the image, expressing impatience with the pace of therapy, or expressing extreme views.

This behavior in the client could signal a protector steering clear of an exile, but it could be in response to a blended part of the therapist. Since our parts could be driving the problem, we check ourselves first. If we find that one of our parts has created a problem, we tell the client. If he has been aware of our part, he feels validated. But even if he hasn't noticed our activated part he is likely to feel relieved that we are willing to be responsible for our parts and pleased that we are being honest. Clients feel reassured when we are transparent and take responsibility for our parts. On the other hand, if our own parts did not interfere, we ask the client to find the part who is engaging in the problematic behavior and invite it to be direct about its concerns and needs. For protectors who have survived by indirection and do not expect to have their views solicited much less respected, this invitation is novel.

Befriending Managers

Befriending involves listening, validating, and honoring the target part. As with all other steps, protectors set the pace and success depends as much on the therapist's level of Self-energy as the client's. Continuing with the example of Dakota, here is an illustration of how we ask these questions.

THERAPIST: What does the witch say?

DAKOTA: She wanted to scare me into being a good girl so my father wouldn't get mad at me anymore.

THERAPIST: Does that make sense to you?

DAKOTA: Jeez. This is sad! All those years of her being so mean to me. She thought it was the right thing to do.

THERAPIST: What do you say to her?

DAKOTA: I'm giving her a hug. What a lousy job.

THERAPIST: How does she respond?

DAKOTA: She's wiping her eyes.

THERAPIST: Does she know you're grown-up now?

DAKOTA: I'm telling her that I'm not that kid anymore. I'm 32 years old. I won't let anyone speak to me that way again.

THERAPIST: What needs to happen?

DAKOTA: She's taking the witch costume off. Since she doesn't want anyone to take it seriously, she's donating it to Goodwill for Halloween.

THERAPIST: What would she like to do now?

DAKOTA: She wants to help out if I ever need to stand up to bullies.

Befriending managers may not work as quickly as this illustration implies, but it is always a powerful move. And because managers will admit to being tired, it is often easier to befriend them than to befriend firefighters. Once Dakota's Self is being kind, the witch confesses that she would rather protect against bullying than be a bully.

EXPLORING FEARS

After the client's Self has befriended the target part, the client (using in-sight) can start asking questions (see [Box 10.2](#)). We suggest asking a series of questions about protectors' fears, which revolve around discovering constraints that keep the part in an extreme role. We also suggest asking

what kind of role the part would prefer. These questions can be used with all protectors, including impulsive, indulgent firefighters and critical, judgmental, striving, perfectionistic managers:

BOX 10.2. Nondirective Questions to Assess Whether the Client's Self Is Present to Take Over

What do you say in response to that?

What needs to happen now?

- Why are you saying or doing this [extreme behavior]?
- What do you really want for [the client's name]?
- What are you afraid would happen if you stopped doing or saying this?
- If [client's name] were able to keep [the feared consequence named by the part] from happening so you could quit this job and do anything you wanted to do, what would that be?
- Would you like us to help you get into that new role?

The following dialogue is an illustration of how we ask these questions.

THERAPIST: This part is very critical of you.

SOL: He thinks I make too many mistakes.

THERAPIST: Do you agree?

SOL: Hmmm. His concern seems a little extreme.

THERAPIST: Ask what he's afraid would happen if he stopped criticizing you.

[This clarifying question is key. When we are finally able to ask a protective part about its fears, we learn about either an exile or a polarized protector. When it points to an exile, we follow the down arrow as illustrated below (And then what would happen? ... and then what?) until the client names the exile (No one would love me), at which point we can offer to help the exile.]

SOL: People won't like me.

[This part's fear points toward the exile who felt rejected.]

THERAPIST: Who won't like you?

SOL: He says my father and older brother.

THERAPIST: Does that make sense to you?

SOL: Kind of. My older brother was the ideal in my family.

THERAPIST: Ask the critic if it would need to keep doing this job if you could heal the part who felt like he was less than your brother?

SOL: It says *no*.

THERAPIST: So if this part didn't have to criticize you anymore, what would it rather do?

SOL: Hmmm. He likes to draw.

THERAPIST: Is it okay with him if you help the one who felt less than your brother now?

[The therapist gets the part's permission before moving forward.]

Note that by inquiring about a protector's fears, the therapist aims to get permission for the client's Self to help the exile it protects, who has been identified during their chat. In this case, the therapist feeds Sol questions for the critic. The more determined the protector, the more the therapist may help out for a while by feeding the client questions. But in general we should be directive for as brief a time as possible. Instead of telling a client what to do or say, as we go along we can test whether the client's Self is ready to take over by asking nondirective questions like, *What do you say in response to that?* and *What needs to happen now?* Once differentiated, the client's Self knows how to deal with the whole system, and the client tells us what the Self is doing rather than asking us what to do.

Hypothetical Questions and Assertions

Notice in the example of interviewing Sol's protector about his fears that the therapist sticks to three strategies: (1) observing and reassuring (see [Box 10.3](#)), (2) asking clarifying questions, and (3) asking hypothetical questions (see [Box 10.4](#)). Whereas all questions aim to help parts unblend, the hypothetical questions dispense with disagreements and arguments. Therefore, the hypothetical question is our magic formula. With a hypothetical question (*If the part were healed, what would it like to do?*) we can introduce new optimistic possibilities while also validating a part's fears and justifiable pessimism: *Of course, we wouldn't want Sol to feel "less than" again, but if he felt safe, would you need to do this job?* The hypothetical question jumps over the controversial concern about whether the exile can be healed—which the critic undoubtedly believes is impossible—and goes straight to the happy ending. We don't ask the part to endorse this happy ending, or even to say it's possible; we simply ask whether a happy ending would be good. In our experience parts only say *no* to this question if we've missed some hidden danger that we need to know about in any case. Most often the part endorses the happy ending as a good outcome but adds that it's not possible. Then we

assert that it is, indeed, possible and we can prove it if the part gives us the chance. Our job is to make this new experiment (the client's Self being present with the exile) seem low cost enough that protectors are willing to try it, even though they are deeply skeptical that it will work.

BOX 10.3. Statements to Reassure Protectors

- # We are not trying to take anything away from you.
- # You are the boss.
- # If you don't like the outcome, you can go right back to doing what you do so well.
- # You are a valued part of [the client's name] and you will always be part of the client, and if this works, you will be free to do something you'd rather do.

BOX 10.4. Hypothetical Questions and Assertions

- # If [the client's name] could help the vulnerable part [the exile] unburden, would you still need to do this job?
- # If we had a new, more effective way of preventing that bad outcome from happening, would you be interested?
- # If it cost you nothing, would you be willing to let us show you how this better outcome is possible?
- # If you don't like the outcome, you can go right back to doing what you do so well.
- # If this works, you will be free to do something you'd rather do.
- # If [the client's name] were able to keep [the feared consequence named by the part] from happening so that you could quit this job and do anything you wanted to do, what would that be?

Additionally, when we use hypothetical questions we never need to argue. If a protector disagrees that something good could happen, which is likely, we just validate its pessimism: *I understand why you would feel that way given your experience.* We serve as the “hope merchant” by asserting our more optimistic perspective, but we don't ask the client's parts to share our optimism. We make an offer, not a display of force. Our offer is to show the part how this process works safely. We ask, *If it costs you nothing to find out, would you be willing to let us show you how this better outcome could be achieved?* We invite, *You can watch, and if it seems too scary, you can interrupt and we'll stop to address your concern.* And we assert, *If what I'm saying doesn't prove true, you can go right back to your job. No one is taking anything away from you. You are the boss.* Protectors who fear ceding control may be slow to take this offer, and protectors who fear the devastation of disappointment

may need to spend quite a bit of time with the therapist's Self through direct access before being willing to meet the client's Self or reveal an exile. But a hypothetical no-cost happy ending is powerfully persuasive over time, and eventually most protectors take the offer.

Manager Fears

People often come to therapy either at the urging of an inner manager or under pressure from an external manager like a parent, spouse, employer, inpatient unit, or court. If the client is blended with either an exile or a firefighter at this time, he is likely to have been mandated or referred in crisis. But if he brings himself in for help, a manager likely made that decision. Do not, however, mistake the initiative of one manager for internal agreement among protective parts about being in therapy. Other managers or firefighters are certainly in the wings with their own concerns and if we don't invite them to speak up, they can block progress.

Managers are driven by fears, many of which are not valid now but were at some point in the client's life. When we understand their fears we are more likely to win their cooperation. Once we address their fears and they are satisfied that cooperating with this new project is safe, managers will let the Self access exiles and will even help rather than resist. Following is a list of common manager fears, also summarized in [Box 10.5](#) (on p. 146). Although not every manager will endorse all of them, most will endorse more than one.

BOX 10.5. Common Manager Fears

1. **Firefighters are dangerous.** Managers need confidence that dangerous firefighters will not deploy as the client's Self approaches the exile.
2. **Exiles overwhelm.** When the Self is emotionally overwhelmed because an exile blends, it is like a cloud covering the sun. The Self is merely hidden, not damaged. Nevertheless, when the Self is hidden, other parts have no way of accessing the Self's leadership and are only aware of the exile's distress. Therefore, managers need to be reassured that the exile can control its level of blending and the Self will show up.
3. **This will be too much for you (the therapist).** Managers need to believe that the therapist is not fragile and will be able to handle the exile's vulnerability without recoiling in disgust, abandoning the client, or becoming disrespectful and punitive.
4. **The therapist will disappear when the client's Self shows up.** Managers need to know that having access to the inner resources of the Self is not a setup for relational abandonment and a future in which the client has to forgo external support in favor of self-sufficiency.

5. **This isn't safe.** Managers need to feel confident that the Self will protect the exile and keep the system safe if the people around the client have dangerous parts.
6. **Something bad could happen.** Managers need to feel confident that the Self can handle punishing consequences like being shunned by family or threatened with violence if an exile exposes secrets or gives up on hopeless attachments.
7. **I will be eliminated.** Managers need to feel confident that they will not be discarded or eliminated when they are no longer needed in extreme roles.
8. **Exiles are their burdens.** Managers need to understand that the exile is not its burdens and that it will transform once released from the constraints of burdens.
9. **Unblending will reveal that [the client's name] is empty and has no Self.** Managers need a new perspective on the client's sense of emptiness, which they take literally. Viewed as the communication of an exiled part, the sense of emptiness is actually a compelling portrait of insecure attachment. The client who feels empty is full of the child's experience of absence.
10. **I will be judged for the damage I have done.** Managers and firefighters need compassion from the client's Self and reassurance that it will mediate if other parts (or people) are angry or judgmental.
11. **Change will destabilize the system and evoke grief.** Managers often need to problem-solve external threats, as well as explore the pros and cons of the exile feeling better and the client having access to a full range of feelings.

Firefighters Are Dangerous

We ask about the risk of rage, suicide, bingeing, and the like before we even try to make contact with an exile. The firefighters who orbit around exiles can be dangerous. If the client gets close to an exile, firefighters can deploy. Some managers are vigilant on this score; others try to deny that firefighters even exist. If a manager denies danger but the client's history says otherwise, we check directly with those firefighters we are aware of. Because internal systems can be very delicately balanced, we need their permission to approach exiles.

Exiles Overwhelm

The fears of protectors motivate much of the behavior that gets clients in trouble and brings them to therapy. The number-one fear of both managers and firefighters is that the client will be overwhelmed by the negative feelings and beliefs of exiles. The fear of emotional overwhelm motivates managers to inhibit and firefighters to distract, often through disinhibition. Many methods of therapy include emotion regulation skills training, as mentioned previously, to help clients

regulate their feelings and forestall impulsivity. In IFS, however, we preempt extreme reactivity by asking the exile not to overwhelm the client with its feelings. The fact that an exile can decide not to overwhelm can save a lot of time and energy for the client. Asking, of course, does not guarantee that the exile will cooperate. But if it trusts the client's (and therapist's) Self, it will usually agree. When an exile does not trust the client's Self, its relationship with the Self must be repaired before we can expect cooperation.

Sometimes an exile is angry because the Self has not been available and the part was forced to look to other people, the majority of whom also failed to help or were actively harmful. But if the Self validates this anger and apologizes the part will soon feel better and accept help. As the rapprochement between the Self and the exile proceeds, managers who have concerns can get nervous and intervene. Most of the time we ask them to step back, but if they persist we listen and address their concerns before returning to the exile. In IFS "resistance" is a manager putting on the brakes. We are, after all, stepping into the delicate inner ecology of a traumatized individual who has good reason not to trust. When we respect and heed managers, and when they believe we know how to move forward safely, they help rather than resist.

It Will Be Too Much for You (the Therapist)

Many clients have a history of being hurt or abandoned by families, peers, or previous therapists when their exiles were exposed, and their protectors fear the same treatment from us. They believe that revealing an exile will destroy the therapeutic relationship, and if the therapist isn't comfortable with his own exiles, this fear is realistic. When our managers get in the driver's seat—or are poised to do so—after a client has exposed an exile, we put our clients at risk. Instead of being the safe, warm, caring people we were when the client risked being vulnerable, we can quickly transform (without conscious intent) into cold, impatient, or distracted people, confirming the client's sense of worthlessness and kicking her protective system into high gear. All this speaks to the importance of therapists staying in close relationship with their parts and maintaining Self-leadership. Therapists who cannot take care of their own exiles should not work with clients' exiles. Once the gates are open and the client has access to her exiles, we have tremendous responsibility. Our clients can ill afford to be rejected, abandoned, or punished by our protectors. We should not open that door until we can commit to being available—no matter what.

In this regard, the opaque therapist, the fearful therapist, and the angry therapist are a particular problem for the client's managers. Being opaque in the role of therapist raises the stakes for managers, especially if negative experiences from the past loom large. Many managers need to feel

that the therapist cares about the client and is not just doing a job, but many therapists have been trained to remain opaque out of concern that expressing care directly will promote unrealistic fantasies or inappropriate enactments in the therapeutic relationship. This unfortunate combination can manufacture a standoff, reinforcing managerial distrust and prolonging therapy. So if you care about a client, we recommend looking for ways to reassure her that you care, including by saying so.

The second concern of the wary manager is the fearful therapist. Many managers, especially those who have experienced trauma, do not trust whole categories of human beings: adults, men, women, anyone who looks or acts differently, etc. This is as true for therapists as for clients. Meanwhile, therapy is a business of relationships. We cannot be frightened of our clients and be in relationship. If our managers spring to the barricades when the client's protectors are manipulative, destructive, or belligerent, then we are not available. In particular, when the client is coming on strong, that special class of manager, the *therapist part* (so called because it is reasonable, rational, well educated, helpful, and easily confused with the Self) may be tempted to try to steer the session into safer waters. Additionally, when a client seems aggressively "needy," it behooves us to appreciate that his requests for direct expressions of care and concern are made on behalf of young parts whose caretaking fantasies about the therapist are expressions of valid, unmet needs. These parts do not need to be controlled, contained, or condescended to; they need to be understood and held in relationship. Meanwhile, our therapist parts do not need to be empowered—they too need to be in relationship—but with our Selves, not with the client's parts. Part-to-part interactions between client and therapist rarely go well.

The third concern, the angry therapist, is equally fraught. The therapist whose firefighters activate in response to challenging clients can pull rank and do all kinds of damage. A firefighter-driven therapist can be bossy, cold, dismissive, contemptuous, punitive, intrusive, seductive, or in denial about danger. A client who is subjected to a therapist's firefighter will be traumatized and set back by the experience. Being in good relationship with our firefighters is a moral imperative for those of us who step into the role of therapist. The IFS model reminds us that everyone has a Self along with other, less hostile parts, and our role is first to do no harm, and second to facilitate the client's Self in providing for her needs.

This Isn't Safe

Bringing exiles into a dangerous environment is unwise and unethical. When a client is unsafe, her managers will resist IFS therapy out of concern that proceeding would expose too much vulnerability. If a client lives with an abusive spouse or family member, we focus on accessing the

client's Self—or, at the least, her mature managers—to change that environment. In addition, as the client becomes stronger and less dependent, people who are close to her, even if they are not dangerous or abusive, may respond in extreme ways. For these reasons, we assess the client's external context before (and during) internal work with vulnerable parts, and facilitate change as needed. If possible, family members can be invited to come in and help their parts, as we illustrate in [Chapter 14](#) on family therapy.

Something Bad Could Happen

Some managers spend years smoothing over or minimizing any hint of wrongdoing on the part of a caretaker. We call these parts *parent protectors*. To comfort exiles who feel unlovable and doomed, these managers are vigilant about warding off the idea that the abuser never loved the client. Managers can also step on the brakes when an angry part wants to confront, reveal, or cut off a person to whom an exile is attached, or someone on whom the client still depends. The IFS model can help managers with all these concerns.

First, once exiles trust the client's Self, they will let go of their dependence on hurtful others. We aim for the client's Self to become the primary attachment figure for all parts. Second, the client needs to know that her healing is not contingent on whether, when, or how she confronts an abuser. That decision should be entirely up to her. Too many clients are encouraged to confront a perpetrator prematurely, well before their internal systems are ready to handle the person's reaction. As a result, they are vulnerable to being emotionally re-abused by denial or counterattack.

Although confronting an abuser is not a condition for healing, the client may want to do so. If this were the case, we would advise taking as much time as he needs to prepare internally, so that his Self remains in the lead and his parts feel safe no matter how the interaction goes. Although this approach is empowering for most clients, some will have parts (usually very young) who associate self-care with abandonment. These young parts will have experienced profound neglect and will be longing for rescue. They can remain stubbornly focused on getting love from others and may refuse to even meet the Self for a long time. We validate their needs and their experience and we explore the fears of the protectors who surround them, coaxing them all into noticing the Self with reassurances that self-care is a prerequisite but not a replacement for being in safe, loving relationships.

I Will Be Eliminated

Many protective parts believe they are nothing more than the roles they fill for the internal system. They have been in their extreme roles for so long and have been so preoccupied with their work that they are not aware of their other talents and desires. In addition, other parts in the system may be eager to eliminate them if their behavior has been oppressive or destructive. As a result, they often fear that they will cease to exist once the exile no longer needs their protection. Our job (that is, the job of the client's Self and the therapist) is to persuade protectors that we appreciate their sacrifices and value them regardless of their role. We ask what they would prefer to do in the future. If they don't know, we assure them that resting is a good idea and that a new, valued role will always be an option. It is remarkable how often the protector's preferred role turns out to be the opposite of its former role. For example, the critic wants to become a cheerleader, the one who made you hide now wants to help you get out in the world with people, and so forth.

Exiles Are Their Burdens

Most protectors believe that the exile is nothing more than their burden. If an exile is young, which is often the case, its views will match its age, including the either-or (*Either I'm good or I'm bad*) and self-referential (*If it happened, I am responsible*) thinking that is characteristic of children. Trying to correct those beliefs cognitively is rarely persuasive with young exiles, but when the Self gets close and extends love, they open up to alternative views.

The Client Has No Self

Managers can insist for long periods of time that the client has no Self. Tempting as it may be to argue, it is most effective to use direct access with parts like this and be curious about what they believe is at stake. What is the worst thing that could happen if the Self did show up? Often they fear they will no longer be needed. Sometimes, however, managers are interpreting a pervasive, insistent sense of inner emptiness as proof that the client has no Self. We can help by pointing out that the adult who feels empty is full of the child's experience of absence, and that parental neglect seems to produce a particularly intense and fraught sense of ongoing vacancy, deadness, or cold in infant parts. This burden, which tells a relational truth and an old story, is a compelling portrait of insecure attachment, but it does not mean the exile is empty, quite the contrary.

The Therapist will Disappear If the Client's Self Shows Up

Parentified young managers have experienced more than their share of relational abandonment. Some will long for external love and support whereas others veer in the direction of caution, advocating self-sufficiency. The parts who long for more connection often hear our invitation to

form a primary relationship with the Self as a prelude to the end of therapy (the therapist will declare success and end therapy), acceptance of permanent isolation, and hope extinguished. At the same time, the parts who oppose the idea of more connection hear our proposal (*Have a relationship with the Self*) as a setup for yet more abandonment. They, too, question our intent when we suggest meeting the Self. Faced with these understandable fears on both sides of the fence, patience is particularly persuasive.

I Will Be Judged for the Damage I Have Done

Firefighters are not the only ones who cause damage. Harsh, rigid, and chronically (often globally) critical managers exact a high price in the client's life. Sometimes the client's Self needs to oversee a kind of internal truth and reconciliation process between injured parts, who need their experience acknowledged, and the parts who have behaved injuriously, who need the opportunity to apologize and renounce their harsh roles. Repairs with external others may also be needed. For this, nothing is more important than the Self, whose courage, clarity, and open heart are essential both in the perpetrator's apology and the injured party's response.

Change Will Destabilize the System and Evoke Grief

Protectors fear grief as a never-ending sadness and portal to depression. As a result, they often go to great lengths to block, numb, and avoid grief. When the protective system lets go of this stance and the Self is there to witness the exile, grief is very likely to be part of the healing process. When parts finally have access to the Self, they grieve because stability and safety allow them to finally feel their losses. As we go along in therapy we therefore need to reassure managers that grief is nature's way of healing and we are all hardwired to grieve productively (Scott, 2016).

CONCLUSION

After we *find* and *flesh out* a target part, preferably a manager, we make sure that the client's Self is available (*feel toward*) and then we facilitate the bond between the target part and the client's Self (*befriend*) so we can learn about its motives (*fears*). Once the client has a relationship with the target part and we know what drives its behavior, we make two essential offers: (1) We can address the part's problem, which is the imperative to protect an exile and (2) we can provide credible help for that exile in the form of the Self. Once a protector has met the client's Self, even if it is loath to trust the Self without further bona fides, it can see that something different is being offered, something that might help solve the actual problem (exiled vulnerability) rather than trying to stop the part from

doing its job. When protectors trust that we understand the validity of their concerns and the method in their madness they are usually willing to risk trying something new.